

DON'T DUCK YOUR DESTINY

BLUE DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE

**BROWN DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO
TECHNICIAN**

INTRO: (Duck Dynasty Video)

This series is a takeoff of the highly rated reality television program, Duck Dynasty. Rather than talking about Duck Dynasty I want to talk about not ducking your destiny. Everyone was sent into this world for a purpose. Not one person who has ever entered the world is an accident, no matter what your parents say!

You are here for a purpose.

I suppose all of us have had moments where we have dreamed of greatness. (Most young people imagine themselves becoming great) - (Larissa talking to her mother about what she wanted to be – How long does it take to become a Doctor, a teacher, a hairdresser...? Life is like a big drum – you have to beat out your own rhythm...!)

Almost everyone begins life with visions and dreams of greatness, but most of us are convinced to live sub-par or mediocre existences. Why? There are probably more reasons than there are people! (A failure to make the grade in school – Being told they will never amount to anything – Being made a victim – A failed marriage – The death of a child – The termination of employment...)

While everyone has a destiny, few achieve it and many become convinced to live a sub-par existence.

For the next few weeks I want us to think about our destiny, why we believe we were permitted to be on this earth; born to our family of origin; given the opportunities we have been afforded; confronted with the obstacles we have been forced to face?

In short, why are we here and what are we supposed to be doing? I want to throw out what I believe to be a life changing truth: Every single human being has been sent into the world for a Divine purpose! [2 Timothy 1:8-9 \(CEV\)](#) ***“Don’t be ashamed to speak for our Lord. And don’t be ashamed of me, just because I am in jail for serving him. Use the power that comes from God and join with me in suffering for telling the good news. 9 God saved us and chose us to be his holy people. We did nothing to deserve this, but God planned it because he is so kind. Even before time began God planned for Christ Jesus to show kindness to us.”*** [Jeremiah 29:11 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”***

If our existence is no accident, then we must believe God has an eternal purpose for us. The fulfillment of our destiny is to live out the purpose of God in this earth, and hear Him say well done at the successful conclusion of our earthly sojourn!

In an attempt to learn how to completely fulfill our destiny I want to focus on a man named Abraham and

his story as it is stated in nineteen verses of the Old Testament book of Genesis chapter twenty-two.

Genesis 22:1-19 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass after these things that God tested Abraham, and said to him, ‘Abraham!’ And he said, ‘Here I am.’² Then He said, ‘Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.’³ So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.⁴ Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.⁵ And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’⁶ So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.⁷ But Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, ‘My father!’ And he said, ‘Here I am, my son.’ Then he said, ‘Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?’⁸ And Abraham said, ‘My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering,’ so the two of them went together.⁹ Then they came to the place of which God had told him. And Abraham built an altar there and placed the wood in order; and he bound Isaac his son and laid him on the altar, upon the wood.¹⁰ And Abraham stretched out his hand and took the knife to slay his son.¹¹ But the Angel of the LORD called to him from heaven and said, ‘Abraham,*

Abraham!’ So he said, ‘Here I am.’¹² And He said, ‘Do not lay your hand on the lad, or do anything to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from Me.’¹³ Then Abraham lifted his eyes and looked, and there behind him was a ram caught in a thicket by its horns. So Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering instead of his son.¹⁴ And Abraham called the name of the place, The-LORD-WILL-PROVIDE; as it is said to this day, ‘In the Mount of The LORD it shall be provided.’ ¹⁵ Then the Angel of the LORD called to Abraham a second time out of heaven,¹⁶ and said: ‘By Myself I have sworn, says the LORD, because you have done this thing, and have not withheld your son, your only son ¹⁷ blessing I will bless you, and multiplying I will multiply your descendants as the stars of the heaven and as the sand which is on the seashore; and your descendants shall possess the gate of their enemies.¹⁸ In your seed all the nations of the earth shall be blessed, because you have obeyed My voice.’¹⁹ So Abraham returned to his young men, and they rose and went together to Beersheba; and Abraham dwelt at Beersheba.”

The successful fulfillment of Abraham’s destiny can be captured in the following five ways:

- Sensitivity
- Submission
- Separation
- Sacrifice
- Stuff

I want to begin this series of sermons by looking at the sensitivity Abraham displayed along the road of pursuing his ultimate destiny.

I. SENSITIVITY

The path to fulfilling our destiny begins with sensitivity. We must learn to be:

- Sensitive to God
- Sensitive to others
- Sensitive to our surroundings

In Genesis chapter twelve we are introduced to a man by the name of Abram. Abram was a man who feared the Lord and had a heart to follow God. Abrams destiny is spelled out in [Genesis 12:1-3 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“Now the LORD had said to Abram: ‘Get out of your country, from your family and from your father’s house, to a land that I will show you. 2 I will make you a great nation; I will bless you and make your name great; and you shall be a blessing. 3 I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse him who curses you; and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.’”***

Abrams destiny is admittedly somewhat vague, but certainly powerful and far-reaching. Because of the realization of his destiny Abram became the father of the Jewish race, and an ancestor of Jesus Christ. Because of this, Abrams destiny is alive and being fulfilled even in our time.

God told Abram to go out and look for a city; He didn't tell him which one but He told him when he found it he would know it. The Bible say's ***“He looked for a city which had foundations whose builder and maker is God”!***

God was not being disingenuous to Abram, by not telling him where He was taking him: God had Abraham enrolled in sensitivity training! Because of what God told Abram regarding the city he was taking him to, he had to treat each city as if this were it!

Much later (At 99 years old), Abram receives a divine revelation; a confirmation of the promise; a name change and for the first time specific instructions concerning the land that he was to possess. [Genesis 17:4-8 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“... Behold, My covenant is with you, and you shall be a father of many nations.⁵ No longer shall your name be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham; for I have made you a father of many nations.⁶ I will make you exceedingly fruitful; and I will make nations of you, and kings shall come from you.⁷ And I will establish My covenant between Me and you and your descendants after you in their generations, for an everlasting covenant, to be God to you and your descendants after you.⁸ Also I give to you and your descendants after you the land in which you are a stranger, all the land of Canaan, as an everlasting possession; and I will be their God.”***

In order to reach his destiny Abraham had to learn to be sensitive! Sensitivity is not imparted it is learned through experience. (Have someone to come up and make only two or three chords – Then have someone an experienced musician come up and play the song)

It was important that Abraham learn to be sensitive because later he would have to find the right mountain on which to offer his son, and even more important, he would need to be sensitive enough to find a ram that would die in place of his son!

Abraham's life was marked by questions like; which direction? Which country? Which city? Which mountain?

The greatest proof of Abrahams sensitivity is revealed in Genesis 22:2-3 (NKJV) when God said to him, *“Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.’ 3 So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.”*

If you and I are going to achieve our destiny we must learn to be sensitive to God, sensitive to others, and sensitive to our surroundings.

We must realize that God has a master plan for our life. This master plan is replete with details, from our mom and dad's bedroom to the funeral parlor; God carefully planned every day of our life before we were a twinkle in our fathers' eye!

God's master plan for our life is not a fast track or overnight success story; but a process that is intended to end with success. [Hebrews 10:36 \(NKJV\) “*For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise:”*](#)

From the time I began Pastoring I began praying “*Lord, help me to be sensitive to the moving of your Holy Spirit.*” Being sensitive to the Holy Spirit has provided direction; prevented potential problems; averted traps; and avoided pitfalls in my life!

Do you see how important it is to be sensitive? The realization of our destiny depends on it, both physically, and spiritually!

The fulfillment of Abraham's destiny was dependent on the level of his sensitivity.

We cannot fulfill our destiny without being sensitive. Anger, frustration, bitterness, strife, etc., are enemies of sensitivity. (Story about frustrated preacher)

When these things are permitted entry into our life all progress toward our destiny ceases.

Are we going to be satisfied with living in a stunted growth process, or are we going to commit ourselves to being sensitive to God, sensitive to others, and sensitive to our surroundings, thus allowing for the fulfillment of our destiny?

II. SUBMISSION TO AUTHORITY

The life of Abraham is a perfect picture of submission to the authority of God and to the authority of man. God called Abraham to go but failed to specify where.

Abraham held a garage sale, told his family good-bye, pulled up the stakes of his tent and went on a expedition of following God. Abraham seems to have done all of this almost without a second thought. How could he go without being furnished more detail? He was able to do such a thing because he was living his life in total submission to God.

Abraham also proved his submission to man in the fact that he was almost too timid in dealing with his family and the Kings who hosted him during his expedition of finding the will of God. (His demeanor in dealing with Lot – His handling of he and Sarah’s relationship with Abimelech – She was the daughter of his father, but not of his mother)

Of all the times Abraham was called upon to submit either to man or God, the greatest test of his submission must have been the call of God to sacrifice his son Isaac. **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)** Genesis 22:1-2 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass after these things that God tested Abraham, and*

said to him, ‘Abraham!’ And he said, ‘Here I am.’² Then He said, ‘Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.’” The first question that comes to mind every time I read this passage of Scripture is; how could God ask a man who has exercised such faith and submission to do such a thing?

All the other times Abraham was called upon to exercise faith and submission must have paled in the face of this test. All the other tests were the proving ground for what would occur on the top of Mt. Moriah. This was to be the greatest test of Abraham’s submission and confidence in God. This incident would no doubt put to the test the belief that God had a destiny that he was taking Abraham too.

This test would no doubt define Abraham’s life; when you hear Abraham spoken of it is rare that this test is not mentioned; When writing to the Hebrews, Paul could not resist the temptation to mention this test; Hebrews 11:17-19 (NKJV) ***“By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises offered up his only begotten son,¹⁸ of whom it was said, ‘In Isaac your seed shall be called,’¹⁹ concluding that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead, from which he also received him in a figurative sense.”***

If Abraham could pass this test everything else would be academic. (Small stuff – don’t sweat the small stuff

– remember, everything is small stuff when God is involved)

Notice Genesis 22:3 ***“So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.”*** Look at this;

no argument; no hedging; no fleeces; he just arose the next morning and started splitting the wood; greasing the wagon wheels; choosing which servants he would take with him and informed his son they were going to a father and son conference on Mt. Moriah! Wow!

What confidence and submission, most of us would have needed to be dragged up Moriah by the hair of the head! We would have gone kicking and screaming; raising multiple objections; stating all kinds of theological questions and telling God how wrong child abuse would be! We would have raised more sand than the alligator did the day the pond went dry!

Abraham did nothing of the sort; he had perfected the art of submission before he ever left Egypt. While at Moriah his submission would move him one giant step closer to his ultimate destiny.

Abraham knew he was destined to be the father of nations. As a result, he knew nothing but his own disobedience could stand between him and his destiny.

Therefore he believed that if God required him to go through with killing his son and cremating him on the altar of sacrifice that God would raise him from the ashes of the fire of sacrifice. Hebrews 11:17-19

(NKJV) ***“By faith Abraham, when he was tested,***

offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises offered up his only begotten son, 18 of whom it was said, 'In Isaac your seed shall be called,' 19 concluding that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead, from which he also received him in a figurative sense."

B. The opposite of submission is rebellion. *Rebellion is a lack of submission.* The Bible reveals some strong statements with regard to rebellion. 1 Samuel 15:23 (NKJV) *"For rebellion is as the sin of witchcraft, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry."*

Submission serves as a voltage regulator for our mind, will, and emotions! It protects us against power surges!

Submission does for us what a governor does to a vehicle:

- *It keeps us accountable*
- *It keeps our actions and reactions at a safe level*
- *It prevents us from running at such high RPM that our other faculties cannot keep pace*
- *It paces us so that more can be accomplished over the long haul*

Submission and accountability are good things not bad things! The Centurion said to Jesus, *"I am a man under authority"*! He did not say *"I am a man in authority"* he said *"I am a man under authority, and I say to one servant, go, and he goeth, and to another come, and he cometh."* Has it ever occurred to you that the centurion was saying, *"I am a man under*

authority; as a result I do not live in fear of my underlings challenging my authority, because they know if they do not submit to my authority they will have to deal with the person that I am submitted to; therefore, I say to my servant go, and he goeth...”

Before you can be a person of authority, you must be a person under authority!

(A young pastor fresh out of Bible College said to my youth pastor, I skipped the youth pastor level and went straight to being a senior pastor! The Youth Pastor went home and told the Children’s Pastor, I skipped the Children’s Pastor level and went straight to being a Youth Pastor!)

Rebellion is a lack of submission. I am quite sure that most of the people in this building today would not think of using a ouguiya board, tarot cards; consult a psychic; a witch; a warlock; or a fortuneteller to find the will of God!

None of us would ever attend a church that would allow such things, yet people set on our pews Sunday after Sunday doing something far worse, they are in rebellion! They are rebelling, they are not under submission!

C. *When considering the subject of submission to authority we discover God has commanded us to be submitted vertically and horizontally.*

Some of us do not have a problem getting used to the idea of submitting to God, after all he holds our very

breath in his hand. Yet, we seem to struggle greatly with horizontal submission.

I am convinced the prevention of destiny in the life of most Christians is an issue of horizontal submission rather than vertical submission!

We are told in the Scripture to submit to the following persons:

- **Governmental leaders** 1 Peter 2:11-15 (NKJV)
“Beloved, I beg you as sojourners and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts which war against the soul,¹² having your conduct honorable among the Gentiles, that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may, by your good works which they observe, glorify God in the day of visitation. ¹³ Therefore submit yourselves to every ordinance of man for the Lord’s sake, whether to the king as supreme,¹⁴ or to governors, as to those who are sent by him for the punishment of evildoers and for the praise of those who do good.¹⁵ For this is the will of God, that by doing good you may put to silence the ignorance of foolish men.”
- **Church Leaders** Hebrews 13:7 (NKJV)
“Remember those who rule over you, who have spoken the word of God to you, whose faith follow, considering the outcome of their conduct.” Hebrews 13:17 (NKJV) “Obey those who rule over you, and be submissive, for they watch out for your souls, as those who must give account. Let them do so with joy and not

with grief, for that would be unprofitable for you.”

- *To one another* Ephesians 5:21 (NKJV)
“Submitting to one another in the fear of God.”

The following pattern of submission is supposed to rule your home:

- *Christ is the head of the home*
- *The husband is to be submitted to Christ*
- *The wife is to be submitted to her husband*
- *The children are to be submitted to their parents*

The following pattern of submission is supposed to rule the Church:

- *Jesus is the head of the Church*
- *The Pastor is the under shepherd of the Church*
- *The Deacons are selected to aid the Pastor in fulfilling the mission of the Church*
- *The people of the Church are to follow the leadership God has provided through the Pastor and Deacons*

There are two times we are called upon to submit; when we feel like it and when we don't, when we understand and when we don't.

I am quite sure Abraham neither felt like submitting nor did he understand what he was being called upon

to do, yet he submitted to the voice of the lord and immediately obeyed. His submission, confidence, and obedience guided him through the most difficult trial of his life and allowed him to emerge as a hero of the faith!

You may very well be walking through the most difficult trial of your life; if so, God has a plan for your celebration of victory!

Remember, just as Abraham of old, the reason you are being called upon to face this trial, is that God is attempting to define your life, and preparing you to occupy the destiny He is calling you to.

Never forget, all the small trials serve to prepare you for a great trial, and the successful navigation of the really BIG ONE will usher in the promise of God and the blessing of the Lord. (When we celebrated our seventh anniversary Susan was so relieved, she said if she missed the rapture she knew she would not have to go through the tribulation because she had already been through it) (A guy once told me that he thought I was the Antichrist; because the Scripture said he would wear out the saints of the most high)

What are the options when faced with a trial such as this? Either submit or take the course over! Can you imagine Abraham having to go to Moriah until he got it right? Moriah is only to be climbed once in a lifetime!

Your Moriah may be a wayward child; a cheating spouse; an illness; a financial collapse; etc... Whatever

you face today, remember, God is in control the whole day through!!!

III. SEPARATION...

A. *Notice the actions of Abraham when he discovers the appointed mountain of testing:* Genesis 22:4-6 (NKJV) *“Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.⁵ And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’⁶ So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.”*

It is interesting to me, at the point of Abrahams greatest trial he was obedient enough to the words of the Lord that he was able to call his obedient response to the seemingly ridiculous command of God, **WORSHIP!**

Faced with similar circumstances, most of us would have demanded better treatment; complained to the pastor; quit the church; or backslid altogether!

Abraham was no quitter he was a courageous man of faith who refused to be controlled by the circumstances of the moment; rather looking to the eventuality of the journey!

Those who choose to place too much emphasis on the circumstances at hand tend to suffer from chronic discouragement and are normally underachievers.

Underachievers rarely go to mountaintops because they are so accustomed to much lower altitudes where

defeat and pity are never more than one battle away!
Most people allow their problems to eclipse their
promise!

I want to ask a question of every person in this place:
Are we placing too much emphasis on the
circumstances of the moment, or are we focused on the
eventuality of the journey?

The answer to this question will have much bearing on
whether or not we achieve the destiny God has called
us to.

B. To this point Abraham has been called upon to
exercise more sensitivity, submission, and separation
than most people are asked to exercise throughout an
entire lifetime.

The bottom line is, *during Abraham's expedition of
finding the will of God and achieving his destiny, he
reached a point where he and Isaac had to separate
themselves from the crowd!* Genesis 22:6 (NKJV) ***"So
Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and
laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his
hand, and a knife, and the two of them went
together."***

Separation has been championed in the church for
centuries. We have been told to separate ourselves
from the world and the people who choose to live
according to its system.

Please understand I believe in sanctification and Holy
living but the church must find a way to make inroads
into the culture it is called to reach. It is my opinion
that the Word of God teaches a doctrine of

“Relevance without Compromise”. ***“Relevance without Compromise” is a belief that we must be relevant to our culture without compromising the message we preach!***

Here is what **“Relevance without Compromise”** should look like in the twenty first century church;

- *The church develops friendships with those who are lost*
- *The church determines the needs of its target audience and makes a commitment to meet them*
- *The church shows the love of Christ in tangible ways*
- *The church demonstrates to sinners they are loved while refusing to participate in their sin*
- *The church preaches a strong message of repentance without being overbearing in the process of modeling and application*

Recently I spoke to a staff member of a charismatic/Pentecostal church who told me they had quit having altar calls because they did not want to offend those who were new in the church!

If you go to a bar this Saturday night do you think they will require all those present to refrain from consuming alcoholic beverages to keep from offending you? Not on your life! The church must continue to preach a strong message but be innovative in the process of modeling and application.

The church of the past century had two major problems that must be corrected in this twenty first century if we are to become what God has intended us to be;

- *It was extremely slow to accept change.* Because we live in the information age the church must be capable of foreseeing paradigm shifts and adjust its ministry to facilitate the trends as they are happening. What if Abraham had waited twenty years to respond to what God had asked of him? He would have probably talked himself out of actually going to Moriah with his son, reasoning this sacrifice was probably unnecessary.
- *Once it began to change it had a tendency to overcompensate.* Going from one extreme to the other is not the answer. We must develop a ministry plan that is consistent and actually works! Overcompensation can be as counterproductive as no change at all! What if Abraham had concluded that if God wanted him to kill his son, it would please God even more if he killed every male in his house?

Our methods must be continually changing but our message and determination to change the culture must never change!

C. Another aspect of this story is the fact *Abraham and Isaac were accompanied to the mountain by a group of servants.* Nowhere does the Bible say that the servants requested to go to the mountain with Abraham! Genesis 22:4-6 (NKJV) ***“Then on the third***

day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.5 And Abraham said to his young men, 'Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.'6 So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together."

Trust me, if I have made this long and grueling journey to the mountain I am going to be more difficult to convince to stay with the donkeys than just being told one time that I can't go to the mountain.

These servants are a little too easy to leave behind! If they had Abrahams best interest at heart they would have been jumping up and down to accompany he and the lad to the summit! If they were the kind of servant that had his back, he could not have gone alone!

I am about to share with you a leadership lesson that if followed will accelerate your destiny, and if ignored will certainly impede or maybe even prevent your destiny:

- Everyone does not desire to go to your mountain
- Everyone does not intend to go to your mountain
- Everyone is not called to your mountain

We spend far too much time and resources attempting to carry unwilling people up the mountainside!

I have attempted this for the past twenty years! I am tired! If you want to go to our mountain you are more than welcome. If you don't want to go stay here with the donkeys, or find you a different mountain to climb or a group of people who like hanging out at low altitudes! (If you want to soar with eagles, quit roosting with turkeys!) (I will not beg you to stay, or refuse your resignation) (What about the good shepherd and the one lost lamb? It was a lamb, not a full grown sheep!)

Can you imagine what would have occurred if Abraham had attempted to physically carry Isaac, his servants and the wagon to the mountain top? He, no doubt would have tired of the journey, collapsing in one big heap of burnout and failed to carry out the plan of God!

While Abraham would have been working hard to get to the mountain top he would have failed to reach the place of sacrifice, thus bringing him into disobedience and judgment! (Plus I would not have had anything to preach on today!)

How many good people do you suppose have fallen prey to this trick?

If those you have been traveling with are not going to the same mountain you are going to leave them behind and continue your pursuit! Kiss them goodbye, bless their STABLE aspirations, and keep climbing! (Did you hear about the horse that fell with the jockey? The last time I heard a report they were both in STABLE condition)

In the pursuit of his destiny Abraham ascended to a height his servants could not attain. He had to separate himself from them and keep on climbing!

If you have a destiny you are focused in on there WILL come a time where separation will occur. The top of the mountain is sparsely populated, but it's worth the cost of the climb! (The 10 spies - The man on whose hand the king leaned)

IV. SACRIFICE...

A. *Abraham and Isaac are an unusually close father and son duo* (Abe is 100 when Ike was born - A few years earlier Abe had to send a son and his mother away – He probably tries to compensate for that loss through Isaac). Isaac is Abraham's pride and joy; the apple of his eye; he thinks the sun rises and sets in him.

I can imagine seeing them hiking up the side of this mountain talking about the things fathers and sons talk about (Fishing – hunting - hiking – camping), and all of a sudden it begins to dawn on Isaac that they do not have a sacrifice and he inquires of his father as to the it's whereabouts. (Kids can be extremely inquisitive – Larissa inquiring about her and Jason's birthdays).

Pay close attention to the inquiry of Isaac and the response of Abraham. Genesis 22:7-8 (NKJV) ***"Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, 'My father!' And he said, 'Here I am, my son.' Then he said, 'Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?'*** ***8 And Abraham said, 'My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering.'*** ***So the two of them went together.***" Isaac

was so confident of his father's leadership and ability to deliver on his promises that you don't hear one more word about the whereabouts of the sacrifice! I wonder; *how confident we are about our Father's ability to make good on the destiny to which He has called us?*

B. Little did Isaac know that he would be involved in a very personal way in the providing of that sacrifice! *Your destiny will probably never be realized until it has exacted from you a very high personal price.*
(Story of chicken and pig – No pain, no gain)

This sacrifice would exact a high price from Isaac but would exact an even higher price from Abraham. Abraham was perfectly willing to give up Isaac in his pursuit of being in the perfect center of the will of God!

A lot of people think that this was not too difficult for Abraham because Abraham believed that if he killed Isaac, that God would raise him from the dead! Maybe so, in fact the scripture say's that he believed God would do exactly that.

Have you ever considered, even if God raised Isaac from the dead what emotional and relational damage could have been done between Abraham and Isaac from that day forward? (Trust would probably be a thing of the past – from that day forward every time Abraham put Isaac in a head-lock Isaac would have a panic attack thinking he was going to break his neck)

Abraham was willing to give up his relationship with his promised son to be where God wanted him to be!

C. *It is extremely rare that anyone achieves their destiny without strapping a sacrifice to the altar.* Most of us will be called upon by God to place multiple things on the altar of sacrifice in order to attain His higher purpose. (I believed I could build a successful construction company)

The question must be asked; how much sacrifice is enough? The answer is until there is no chance of our being lifted up in pride when we stand victoriously on the summit of our success!

T.D. Jakes said, ***“The only way you will ever know how bad you want it, is to determine how much you are willing to give up to get it!”***

The price of sacrifice is never small; otherwise it would not be a sacrifice! (It would be no sacrifice at all to me to give up eating cheese, but it is a tremendous sacrifice to fast ten day's) For you to stand on the summit of your destiny you will likely be called upon to sacrifice something you love!

In the book of Judges Chapter eleven we are introduced to a man by the name of Jephthah. Jephthah was conceived from a union between his father and a prostitute. The Bible says that Jephthah was a mighty man of valor. When Jephthah's father and his wife had children and they grew up, those sons threw Jephthah out of the house. (Jephthah grew up in a dysfunctional household – A cheating father – A jealous step-mother – Angry half-brothers - What's your excuse?)

A few years later the Ammonites began to threaten the land and all of a sudden Jephthah was a hot

commodity again! (Every great leader goes through times of isolation – Moses – Elijah – John the Baptist – Jesus – us!)

They promised him that if he would consent to leading the nation in a successful war effort they would make him the leader of the land. (God intends to make you the head and not the tail – In His good time)

Before Jephthah went to battle he prays to God and before he finishes praying he makes a vow to God Judges 11:30-31 (NKJV) ***“Jephthah made a vow to the LORD, and said, ‘If You will indeed deliver the people of Ammon into my hands,31 then it will be that whatever comes out of the doors of my house to meet me, when I return in peace from the people of Ammon, shall surely be the LORD’s, and I will offer it up as a burnt offering.’”***

Jephthah went to battle against the Ammonites and God miraculously delivered them into his hand. Notice what happened when Jephthah returned home from the battle Judges 11:34-35 (NKJV) ***“When Jephthah came to his house at Mizpah, there was his daughter, coming out to meet him with timbrels and dancing; (I can remember when I was no more than 3 or 4 years old waiting at the end of the driveway for my dad to come home from work; when I heard his panel van coming my heart rate began to quicken and the excitement was almost more than I could bear; Dad would stop and let me ride on the running board of that panel van back to the house) and she was his only child. Besides her he had neither son nor daughter.35 and it came to pass, when he saw her***

that he tore his clothes, and said, ‘Alas, my daughter! You have brought me very low! You are among those who trouble me! For I have given my word to the LORD, and I cannot go back on it.’”

Achieving your destiny will not always be comfortable or easy.

Sir Edmund Hillary made several unsuccessful attempts at climbing Mt. Everest before he finally succeeded. After one attempt he stood at the base of that giant mountain and shook his fist at it. In defiance he said *“I’ll defeat you yet because you’re as big as you are going to get, but I’m still growing.”*

Though climbing to the peak of your destiny will not be easy you’re stay at the top will be worth the climb.

What would you be willing to sacrifice to go to the mountain peak of your destiny?

V. STUFF!

A. *Webster defines the word stuff in the following ways:*

- *The material out of which anything is or can be made*
- *Basic elements*

Not everything in our life comes in nice neat and expensively wrapped packages. Most things require some assembly. (Assembling swing set for Jason)

Abraham and Isaac had the...

- ...wagon, the wood, and the fire...
- ...the transportation, the fuel, and the passion...

- ...the courage, the determination, and the resolve...

...the only thing they lacked was the sacrifice!
Abraham said ***“God will provide for himself a sacrifice”***. All they needed was the ear to listen, the hands to help, and the heart to respond, as God led them step by step into a holy setup!

This world’s system say’s if you have a need what you need is a hand-out; someone to come running to your rescue. You don't need a handout, you need a setup! A handout is being given something you neither worked nor planned for. A setup is something you have participated in from the beginning!

Abraham and Isaac had participated in this setup from the beginning:

- *They readied the wagon and donkeys*
- *They split the wood*
- *They selected the servants*
- *They packed the gear*
- *They made the trip*
- *They climbed the mountain*

Can you see a Divine setup about to transpire? As you read this story, the anticipation begins to build; the expectancy begins to rise; the sense of the miraculous teeters precariously on the edge; the adrenalin begins to flow; you just know God is about to do something supernaturally spectacular.

Why can't we see our own miracle coming? God did not love Abraham any more than He loves you! If you will be faithful in spite of the pain and the problems God will set you up for victory!

If you fail the faithfulness test you will have to settle for a handout! A banker; a lawyer; a doctor; a priest; a marriage counselor can facilitate a handout, but it takes Divine intervention to bring about a setup!

Not everyone can participate in a setup! Some folks are predisposed to mess-up a set-up! I believe God spoke to me and said the reason Abraham did not take his servants, and the reason they never asked to go is because they would have interfered, rather than participated in the setting of the stage for the miracle and act of divine love God was about to demonstrate to his FRIEND Abraham!!

People who are more comfortable with a handout than a setup will:

- Crash rather than climb!
- Complain rather than confess!
- Sit rather than shout!
- Get bitter rather than better!

B. Isaac said, “*Father, here is the wood, and here is the fire, but where is the sacrifice?*”

The manner in which Isaac sees the circumstances is much different than the way Abraham sees them. What is the difference? T.D. Jakes said “*A boy can see the*

stuff, but a man knows how to put it all together!”

(The Swing set)

God has given us the stuff, all we have to do is put it all together according to his instructions, and within his timing!

Even a man must have the help of the Lord in putting all of the pieces together, thus unveiling the picture God had in mind from the beginning! (God knew me before I was born, and planned each day of my life! I know the plans God has for me. they are plans to bless me, and not to harm me!)

God provided for Abraham the stuff for a sacrifice but it was up to him to put it all together!

This wasn't a handout, it was a setup!!! A setup consists of being sensitive to God and man; being in submission to authority; separating yourself from the company of those who are not going to your destiny; sacrificing the things that cause pride; and receiving the stuff God has provided!

Abraham and Isaac reach the summit of their mountain, and begin to build an altar! (BRING THE ALTAR IN: AS THE ALTAR IS BROUGHT IN ABRAHAM AND ISAAC ENTER AND BEGIN RUMMAGING AROUND FOR STONES, AND PLACE THE WOOD ON THE ALTAR)

C. To This point Abraham fully intended to sacrifice his son! (ABRAHAM PUTS HIS ARM AROUND ISAAC AS IF EXPLAINING WHAT IS ABOUT TO

HAPPEN – HE THEN PLACES HIM ON THE WOOD AND TIES HIM DOWN)

Abraham planned to sacrifice his son, but God had another plan. When he raised the knife to take the life of his son, God spoke to him about a ram caught in a thicket behind him! (THE ANGEL COMES OUT OF THE ALTAR AND CATCHES ABRAHAM BY THE ARM –TAKES THE KNIFE AWAY AND POINTS TO THE STAGE DOOR WHERE AN ANGEL COMES OUT LEADING A RAM)

A ram is uniquely designed to negotiate briar patches without being trapped by them! What in the world is wrong with this ram? It wasn't the briar patch, his GPS (Global Positioning System) was working wonderfully. This ram had not experienced a lack of stamina it was a holy stakeout! God tied the ram by his horns in the thicket so Abraham would have a substitute!

Think about it, Abraham has stomped all over this mountain getting just the right rocks. He and Isaac have no doubt had a conversation (Maybe even a heated exchange) about what was about to transpire and this ram never made a sound? This was a holy stakeout!

I believe Abraham was so glad to see this ram that he felt like kissing him right on the lips in spite of the fact that the ram had chronic halitosis! Have you ever been there? God provided a substitute for you! A ram for a son, a son for a sin! There is no better substitute!

Abraham was sensitive enough to hear at a moments notice! How far in advance does God have to start speaking to you to bring about a minor; let alone a major change in your life?

Is God free to pull off a setup in your life at a moments notice? In order to receive a setup rather than a handout you have to be capable of transitioning at a moments notice. *Miracles are made in moments of flexibility!*

Abraham had offered dozens if not hundreds of sacrifices and not one time had God taken one sacrifice down to offer a different sacrifice! What would have happened if Abraham had been too traditional to transition?

Some of us can't receive a holy setup because we strapped the wrong sacrifice to the altar in the beginning and we can't accept the fact that God had something else in mind!

The church needs less tradition and more transition!

Businesses fail, nations crumble, marriages end in divorce, careers are brought to an abrupt halt, denominations lose their effectiveness, ministries die, churches decline, people backslide because of an inability to transition! Some people would rather fight than switch! (Use old commercial!) (Story about Swiss watchmakers refusing to adapt to the quartz watch - Has led to sharing a very small part of the market, and extremely reduced profit margins)

When you are involved in a holy setup you will discover your sacrifice tied up in a stakeout and when you make that discovery you will realize that the only you contributed to the final outcome was by being sensitive; being submitted; separating yourself; making some sacrifices; and being ready to receive some stuff!

Your substitute is waiting in the wings; he has been tied up and is awaiting your discovery! If you can find your substitute you will discover the stuff to bring your dream to fruition!